FAITHFUL IN GOD'S HOUSEHOLD

Small-group kit

Six sessions for home groups and small groups – one per chapter, 75 to 90 minutes each. Each session builds on that week's devotionals.

SESSION 1	Guard the Gospel	1 Timothy 1:1–20
SESSION 2	Prayer for All, Worship in Order	1 Timothy 2:1–15
SESSION 3	Leaders for God's Household	1 Timothy 3:1–16
SESSION 4	Training for Godliness	1 Timothy 4:1–16
SESSION 5	The Church as a Family	1 Timothy 5:1–25
SESSION 6	Real Wealth, Real Life	1 Timothy 6:1–21

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SESSION 1 · 1 TIMOTHY 1:1–20

Guard the Gospel

THE BIG IDEA

Sound teaching is known by its fruit – love, a good conscience and sincere faith – and at its heart stands the gospel of grace for sinners like Paul and like us.

TO GET STARTED

Think of something precious someone once entrusted to you – a key, a child, a secret. How did it change the way you behaved?

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 1:1–20

Read in three parts with three readers: verses 1–11 (the problem in Ephesus), verses 12–17 (Paul's testimony – read slowly, ending with the doxology), verses 18–20 (the charge to Timothy).

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul has left Timothy behind in Ephesus, a busy port city full of temples and ideas, to deal with people who were teaching "a different doctrine". This letter is Paul's instruction for how the church should live as God's household. Tonight we read chapter 1: the danger of false teaching, Paul's own story of grace, and a charge to Timothy to stay in the fight.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- **telos tēs parangelias – τέλος τῆς παραγγελίας** "the goal of our instruction": The goal of all teaching is not winning debates but "love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith" (1:5). Teaching that breeds pride and quarrels has missed its goal.
- **pistos ho logos – πιστὸς ὁ λόγος** "this is a trustworthy saying": The first of five "trustworthy sayings" in the Pastoral Letters (1:15). It anchors the church in a simple confession: "Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners."
- **strateia – στρατεία** "warfare": Timothy is to "wage the good warfare" (1:18) – a long military campaign, not a single battle. Faith and a good conscience are his equipment; without them faith suffers shipwreck.

DISCUSSION

1. What were the false teachers in Ephesus busy with, according to verses 3–7? What might "myths and endless genealogies" look like in church life today? (1 Timothy 1:3–7)
2. Paul says the goal of instruction is "love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith". How can we tell whether teaching we hear is "sound"? (1 Timothy 1:5)
3. Paul describes himself as "a blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man". Why do you think he tells his own story at this point in the letter? (1 Timothy 1:13)
4. Paul says "of them I am the first" – present tense, not past. What does this tell us about how a mature Christian sees himself or herself? (1 Timothy 1:15)
5. Paul's testimony ends in worship (v. 17). When did thinking about God's grace last lead you to praise? (1 Timothy 1:17)

6. “Some have pushed this conscience aside and have made shipwreck of their faith.” How can ignoring our conscience slowly wreck our faith? (1 Timothy 1:19)
7. Where is your conscience “flashing a warning light” at the moment? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Write down your own short “testimony of grace” (three or four sentences, as Paul does in verses 12–16) and share it with one person this week.
- Ask God each evening this week: “Is there anything I am pushing aside in my conscience?” – and act on one thing he shows you.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 1:17 aloud together as praise. Then pray in pairs: thank God for his mercy to each of you, and pray for people you know who have “made shipwreck” of their faith, that they would be restored.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (days 1–3). Choose four or five questions and leave time for the last one.
- The list in verses 9–10 (including “men who have sex with men”) can derail the evening. Acknowledge it, note that Paul's point is the right use of the law and the gospel of grace for all sinners – including himself in verse 13 – and keep the focus there.
- Verse 20 (“handed over to Satan”) raises questions. The day 3 devotional explains it as formal church discipline whose aim is restoration (“so that they may be taught not to blaspheme”); you don't need to resolve every detail.
- Some may carry deep shame about their past. Verses 12–16 are good news for them – let the group dwell on them rather than rushing on.
- Point ahead: next week chapter 2 turns to prayer “for all people” and to worship in the church.

Related devotionals: Day 1 – Guarding the Purity of the Gospel · Day 2 – Grace for the Worst of Sinners · Day 3 – Wage the Good Warfare with a Good Conscience

1 Timothy 1:1–20

1 Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the command of God our Saviour and of Christ Jesus our hope, 2 to Timothy, my true child in the faith: grace, mercy and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord.

3 As I urged you when I was going on to Macedonia, stay on in Ephesus, so that you may instruct certain people not to teach a different doctrine 4 and not to occupy themselves with myths and endless genealogies, which produce speculations rather than God's ordering of things, which is by faith – 5 but the goal of our instruction is love from a pure heart, from a good conscience and from a sincere faith. 6 Some have strayed from these and have turned aside to empty talk. 7 They want to be teachers of the law, without understanding either what they are saying or the things about which they make such confident claims. 8 Now we know that the law is good, if one uses it lawfully, 9 knowing this: the law is not laid down for the righteous, but for the lawless and rebellious, for the ungodly and sinners, for the unholy and profane, for those who kill their fathers or their mothers, for murderers, 10 for the sexually immoral, for men who have sex with men, for slave traders, for liars, for perjurers, and for whatever else is contrary to sound teaching, 11 in keeping with the gospel of the glory of the blessed God, which was entrusted to me.

12 I give thanks to him who has strengthened me, Christ Jesus our Lord, because he judged me faithful and appointed me to his service, 13 though I was formerly a blasphemer, a persecutor and a violent man. But I was shown mercy, because I acted in ignorance and unbelief. 14 And the grace of our Lord overflowed, together with the faith and love that are in Christ Jesus. 15 This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance: Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners – and of them I am the first. 16 But for this very reason I was shown mercy: so that in me, as the first, Christ Jesus might display his complete patience, as an example for those who were going to believe in him for eternal life.

17 Now to the King of the ages,
the imperishable, invisible, only God,
be honour and glory for ever and ever. Amen.

18 This instruction I entrust to you, Timothy, my child, in keeping with the prophecies once made about you, so that by them you may wage the good warfare, 19 holding on to faith and a good conscience. Some have pushed this conscience aside and have made shipwreck of their faith. 20 Among them are Hymenaeus and Alexander, whom I have handed over to Satan, so that they may be taught not to blaspheme.

SESSION 2 · 1 TIMOTHY 2:1–15

Prayer for All, Worship in Order

THE BIG IDEA

God "wants all people to be saved", so the church's first task is prayer for all – and its worship should reflect reconciled hearts, holy lives and God's good order.

TO GET STARTED

Who is a public figure – a politician, a celebrity, a CEO – you find hard to pray for? (No need to say why.)

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 2:1–15

Read verses 1–7 with one reader and say the confession in verses 5–6 together as a group; then a second reader reads verses 8–15 slowly.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

After warning against false teaching, Paul turns to the life of the church gathered for worship. First he urges prayer for all people, including rulers, because there is one God and one mediator. Then he speaks to men and women about how they pray, dress, learn and serve – some of the most discussed verses in the New Testament.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***mesitēs* – μεσίτης** "mediator": A mediator stands between two estranged parties to reconcile them. There is "one mediator between God and humankind, the man Christ Jesus" (2:5) – no other bridge is needed or possible.
- ***antilytron* – ἀντίλυτρον** "ransom": Christ "gave himself as a ransom for all" (2:6). The prefix anti- means "in the place of": our freedom was bought at the cost of his own life.
- ***hēsychia* – ἡσυχία** "quietness": The same root as the "peaceful and quiet life" Paul wants for all believers (2:2). In 2:11–12 it describes a peaceful, teachable spirit – not a humiliating silence.

DISCUSSION

1. Paul lists "petitions, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings". Which of these is strongest in your prayer life, and which is weakest? (1 Timothy 2:1)
2. Why does Paul link praying for rulers with God, "who wants all people to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth"? (1 Timothy 2:1–4)
3. Read verses 5–6 again. What difference does it make in daily life that there is only one mediator? (1 Timothy 2:5–6)
4. Men are to pray "lifting up holy hands without anger or quarrelling". How can unresolved anger block our prayers? (1 Timothy 2:8)
5. Paul contrasts outward adornment with "good works". Where do we invest more – in our image or in our character? (1 Timothy 2:9–10)
6. Paul says "A woman should learn" – in its culture a remarkable command. What do verses 11–15 say, and what do they not say? Listen carefully to one another here. (1 Timothy 2:11–15)
7. Whom do you find hardest to pray for – and what would change if you prayed for them regularly?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one political leader and one person you disagree with, and pray for each of them by name every day this week.
- If there is anger or a quarrel between you and someone else, take one step towards reconciliation before next week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray around the circle for leaders in your town, country and the world, using the four kinds of prayer from verse 1. Close by saying verses 5–6 together as a confession of faith.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Give verses 1–7 real time: they are the heart of the chapter and the most practical. Don't let verses 11–15 swallow the whole evening.
- Verses 11–15 are understood differently by sincere Christians. The day 5 devotional follows Hannes's position: God's complementary order for men and women in the church, grounded in creation (verse 13) and not in superiority or inferiority (Galatians 3:28). Present it as such, and let others in the group say where they see it differently.
- Set the tone early: we listen to understand, not to win. Keep to what the text says; the translation notes explain choices such as “exercise authority” (verse 12) and “quietness”.
- Verse 15 is difficult. The day 5 devotional says it cannot mean earning salvation by giving birth, and points to Genesis 3:15 (the promised offspring). It's fine to leave some questions open.
- Be sensitive to single, childless or widowed people and to anyone hurt by church experiences in this area. Offer to talk afterwards.

Related devotionals: Day 4 – Prayer for All and the One Mediator · Day 5 – An Attitude of Worship and Godliness

1 Timothy 2:1–15

1 First of all, then, I urge that petitions, prayers,
intercessions and thanksgivings be made for all
people, 2 for kings and all who are in high posi-
tions, so that we may lead a peaceful and quiet
life in all godliness and dignity. 3 This is good
and pleasing before God our Saviour, 4 who
wants all people to be saved and to come to the
knowledge of the truth.

5 For there is one God,
and there is one mediator between God and
humankind,
the man Christ Jesus,
6 who gave himself as a ransom for all –
the testimony at the proper time.

7 For this I was appointed a herald and an apos-
tle – I am telling the truth, I am not lying – a
teacher of the nations in faith and truth.

8 I want the men, then, to pray in every place,
lifting up holy hands without anger or quar-
relling. 9 Likewise also the women should
adorn themselves in respectable clothing, with
modesty and self-control, not with braided hair
and gold or pearls or expensive clothing, 10 but –
as is fitting for women who profess reverence
for God – with good works. 11 A woman should
learn in quietness, in all submission. 12 I do not
permit a woman to teach, nor to exercise au-
thority over a man; she is to be in quietness.
13 For Adam was formed first, then Eve. 14 And
Adam was not deceived, but the woman was de-
ceived and fell into transgression. 15 But she will
be saved through childbearing, if they remain
in faith and love and holiness, with self-
control.

SESSION 3 · 1 TIMOTHY 3:1–16

Leaders for God's Household

THE BIG IDEA

The church is God's household and "a pillar and foundation of the truth", so its leaders are chosen for tested character more than talent – and all godliness flows from the mystery of Christ.

TO GET STARTED

If you had to hire someone to look after your house and family while you were away for a year, what would matter most to you?

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 3:1–16

One reader for verses 1–7 (overseers), another for verses 8–13 (deacons), a third for verses 14–15; then the whole group reads the hymn in verse 16 together, line by line.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

The crisis in Ephesus was at heart a leadership crisis. In chapter 3 Paul sets out what overseers and deacons must be like – almost all of it about character, very little about skills. Then he explains why: the church is the household of the living God, and he ends with an early Christian hymn about Christ.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***anepilēmptos* – ἀνεπίλημπτος** "above reproach": The heading over the whole list (3:2): a picture from wrestling – someone with nothing an opponent can grab hold of. Not sinless, but without obvious footholds for accusation.
- ***dokimazō* – δοκιμάζω** "be tested": Of deacons Paul says: "let them also be tested first" (3:10) – the word for testing precious metals in fire. Character is proved over time, before a public task is given.
- ***eusebeia* – εὐσέβεια** "godliness": The letter's key word. "great is the mystery of godliness" (3:16): true godliness is not produced by willpower, it flows from wonder at who Christ is and what he has done.

DISCUSSION

1. Read through the qualities in verses 2–7. How many are about skills, and how many about character? What does that tell us? (1 Timothy 3:2–7)
2. Why is the way someone manages his own household a test for leading "God's church"? (1 Timothy 3:4–5)
3. Why should a leader "have a good reputation with outsiders"? How do colleagues and neighbours see our church – and us? (1 Timothy 3:7)
4. Deacons are to be "not double-tongued". Why is consistency in our words so important in a church family? (1 Timothy 3:8)
5. The church is "the household of God … a pillar and foundation of the truth". Do we treat our local church more like a household or like a service provider? (1 Timothy 3:15)
6. Read the hymn in verse 16 slowly. Which line speaks to you most today, and why? (1 Timothy 3:16)
7. These qualities are for leaders, but they describe every mature Christian. Which one would you like God to grow in you?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Pray this week for the leaders of your church by name, using one quality from verses 2–13 for each of them.
- Take on one quiet, unseen task of service in your church or home this week, without telling anyone.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for the overseers, elders and deacons of your church. Then read the hymn of verse 16 aloud once more and turn each line into a short sentence of praise.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (days 6–8). Choose four or five questions; question 6 on the hymn makes a good ending.
- Be careful that the evening doesn't become a critique of current church leaders. Keep the focus on what God values and on our own character.
- Phrases like “husband of one wife” (3:2, 12) and “women” (3:11 – deacons' wives or women deacons; the day 7 devotional leaves both options open) can lead to long debates. Acknowledge the questions and return to the main point: tested character.
- Some in the group may feel disqualified because of divorce, family struggles or past failures. Remind them of last week's theme: grace for the worst of sinners.
- Verse 16 reads “He was revealed in the flesh”; older Bibles read “God”. Our translation follows the Greek text used for it (SBLGNT); the day 8 devotional explains the difference. Either way, the hymn is clearly about Christ.

Related devotionals: Day 6 – The Character of a Spiritual Leader (Overseers) · Day 7 – Faithful Service and Integrity (Deacons) · Day 8 – The Pillar of Truth and the Mystery of Godliness

1 Timothy 3:1–16

[1] This is a trustworthy saying: if anyone aspires
to the office of overseer, he desires a good work.
[2] The overseer, then, must be above reproach,
the husband of one wife, sober-minded, self-
controlled, respectable, hospitable, able to
teach, [3] not a drunkard, not violent but gentle,
not quarrelsome, not a lover of money, [4] one
who manages his own household well and
keeps his children in submission, with all dig-
nity – [5] for if someone does not know how to
manage his own household, how will he take
care of God's church? – [6] not a recent convert, so
that he does not become conceited and fall into
the condemnation of the devil. [7] He must also
have a good reputation with outsiders, so that
he does not fall into disgrace and into the
devil's trap. [8] Deacons likewise must be digni-
fied, not double-tongued, not given to much
wine, not greedy for dishonest gain, [9] holding
the mystery of the faith with a clear conscience.
[10] And let them also be tested first; then let them
serve, if they prove blameless. [11] Women like-
wise must be dignified, not slanderers, sober-
minded, faithful in all things. [12] Deacons must
each be the husband of one wife, managing
their children and their own households well.
[13] For those who have served well gain a good
standing for themselves and great confidence in
the faith that is in Christ Jesus.

[14] I am writing these things to you, though I
hope to come to you soon, [15] so that, if I am de-
layed, you may know how one ought to behave
in the household of God, which is the church of
the living God, a pillar and foundation of the
truth. [16] And beyond all question, great is the
mystery of godliness:

He was revealed in the flesh,
vindicated by the Spirit,
seen by angels,
proclaimed among the nations,
believed in throughout the world,
taken up in glory.

SESSION 4 · 1 TIMOTHY 4:1–16

Training for Godliness

THE BIG IDEA

False piety says “Don't touch” and makes people anxious; true godliness receives God's good gifts with thanksgiving and is trained day by day – in the leader's own life first.

TO GET STARTED

What is something you have trained for – a sport, an instrument, a language? What did it take to keep going when it got boring?

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 4:1–16

Read in three parts with three readers: verses 1–5 (the warning), verses 6–10 (the training), verses 11–16 (the young leader). Pause briefly between the parts.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Chapter 3 ended with the hymn to Christ, “the mystery of godliness”. Chapter 4 now shows its counterfeit: teachers in Ephesus who forbid marriage and certain foods and call that holiness. Against them Paul sets two things – thankful enjoyment of God's good creation, and a young leader who trains himself for godliness and keeps watch over his own life.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***gymnazō* – γύμναζε σεαυτὸν πρὸς εὐσέβειαν** “train yourself for godliness”: The word that gives us “gymnasium”. Godliness is not a feeling that falls on us but something trained with regular, sometimes sweaty effort (4:7) – and unlike bodily training, it pays off in both this life and the next (4:8).
- ***kekaustēriasmenōn* – κεκαυστηριασμένων τὴν ἰδίαν συνείδησιν** “whose own consciences have been branded”: A conscience seared as with a branding iron no longer feels anything (4:2). The false teachers could sound very strict and still be dead inside.
- ***typos* – τύπος** “example”: Timothy's answer to people who look down on his youth is not a title but a life that others can copy: “in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity” (4:12).

DISCUSSION

1. What exactly did the false teachers forbid, and what is Paul's answer? Look closely at verses 3 to 5. (1 Timothy 4:3–5)
2. “For everything created by God is good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving.” Where do Christians today still make holiness a matter of avoiding things rather than receiving them gratefully? (1 Timothy 4:4)
3. Paul says, “Rather, train yourself for godliness.” What would a realistic “training plan” for godliness look like in your week? (1 Timothy 4:7)
4. Bodily training is of “little value”, godliness of value “in every way”. Where do our time and money show what we really value more? (1 Timothy 4:8)
5. “Let no one look down on you because of your youth.” What does Paul tell Timothy to do instead of demanding respect? What could that mean for younger people in our church – and for how older people

treat them? (1 Timothy 4:12)

6. Paul names reading Scripture aloud, exhortation and teaching (4:13). Which of these is strongest in our group, and which do we neglect? (1 Timothy 4:13)
7. "Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching." Why do both belong together? Where is it easier for you to watch one and neglect the other? (1 Timothy 4:16)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Choose one small, daily "exercise" of godliness for this week (for example, ten minutes of Scripture before your phone, or thanksgiving before every meal) and tell one person in the group which one.
- Pay attention to one good gift of God you usually take for granted – food, rest, a relationship – and receive it this week consciously "with thanksgiving".

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together for his good gifts, naming specific ones. Then pray in pairs for each other's "training" in godliness, and for younger people in the church who serve or are just starting to serve.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (Days 9–11). Choose four or five questions; question 3 and question 7 are the heart of the chapter.
- The "later times" in 4:1 can lead to speculation about the end times. Keep the focus on what the text applies it to: teaching that makes people anxious instead of grateful.
- Verse 4:8 can make sporty people feel judged. Point out, as Day 10 does, that Paul calls bodily training of limited value, not worthless.
- If there are younger members in the group, let them answer question 5 first; older members often have the most to learn from listening.
- Verse 4:10 ("the Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe") may raise questions. Note it, but don't let it take over the evening; it can be discussed separately.

Related devotionals: Day 9 – A Warning against Falling Away and False Piety · Day 10 – Train Yourself for Godliness · Day 11 – An Example in Speech and Conduct (Keep Watch on Yourself)

1 Timothy 4:1–16

1 Now the Spirit says explicitly that in later
times some will fall away from the faith, devoting themselves to deceiving spirits and teachings of demons, 2 through the hypocrisy of liars
whose own consciences have been branded.
3 They forbid marriage and demand abstinence
from foods that God created to be received with thanksgiving by those who believe and know
the truth. 4 For everything created by God is
good, and nothing is to be rejected if it is received with thanksgiving, 5 for it is made holy
by the word of God and prayer.

6 If you put these things before the brothers and
sisters, you will be a good servant of Christ
Jesus, nourished on the words of the faith and
of the good teaching that you have followed.
7 But have nothing to do with irreverent, old
wives' myths. Rather, train yourself for godliness. 8 For bodily training is of little value, but
godliness is of value in every way, holding
promise for the present life and for the life to
come. 9 This is a trustworthy saying and deserves full acceptance. 10 For to this end we toil
and are reviled, because we have set our hope
on the living God, who is the Saviour of all people, especially of those who believe.

11 Instruct people in these things and teach
them. 12 Let no one look down on you because of
your youth, but set the believers an example in
speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity.
13 Until I come, devote yourself to the public
reading of Scripture, to exhortation and to
teaching. 14 Do not neglect the gift that is in
you, which was given to you through prophecy
when the council of elders laid their hands on
you. 15 Put these things into practice, give yourself wholly to them, so that your progress may
be evident to all. 16 Keep a close watch on yourself and on your teaching; persist in them. For
by doing this you will save both yourself and
those who hear you.

SESSION 5 · 1 TIMOTHY 5:1–25

The Church as a Family

THE BIG IDEA

God's household is a family: we treat each other as fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters, care concretely for those who are truly alone, and honour and correct leaders fairly and without favouritism.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

TO GET STARTED

Who was a "spiritual father" or "spiritual mother" to you – someone outside your own family who shaped your faith? What did they do?

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 5:1–25

The chapter is long. Read it in three sections with different readers: verses 1–8, verses 9–16, verses 17–25.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Paul has called the church "the household of God" (3:15). In chapter 5 he shows what that means in everyday life: how to speak to older and younger people, how to look after widows who have no one, and how to treat elders – with honour, but also with fair correction. It is the most practical chapter of the letter, and some of it is far from our world; the principles behind it are not.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***ontōs chēra* – τὰς ὄντως χήρας** "truly widows": Paul uses this phrase three times (5:3, 5, 16). The church's help is meant first for those who really have no one else – families are to take responsibility for their own first (5:4, 8).
- ***parakalei* – μὴ ἐπιπλήξῃς, ἀλλὰ παρακάλει** "do not rebuke … harshly, but encourage": Even necessary correction is to happen in a family tone: an older man as a father, younger men as brothers (5:1). The word for "encourage" comes from the same root as the Holy Spirit's name, the Paraclete.
- ***diplē timē* – διπλῆς τιμῆς** "double honour": Elders who lead well and labour in preaching and teaching deserve respect and also practical support (5:17–18) – and when they sin, they are not exempt from correction (5:19–20).

DISCUSSION

1. How should Timothy speak to older men, younger men, older women and younger women? What changes if we really treat the church as a family? (1 Timothy 5:1–2)
2. "Honour widows who are truly widows." Who are the people in our church and town today who are "truly alone"? How would we know? (1 Timothy 5:3)
3. Paul is very sharp in verse 8: whoever does not provide for his own relatives "has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever". Why does care for our own families weigh so heavily? (1 Timothy 5:8)
4. The widows on the list were known for hospitality, washing the feet of the saints and helping the afflicted (5:10). What does this list tell us about what God values in a life? (1 Timothy 5:10)
5. Elders are "worthy of double honour", yet accusations need two or three witnesses, and sin is rebuked openly (5:17–20). How can a church honour its leaders and still hold them accountable? (1 Timothy 5:17–20)

6. “Do not be hasty in the laying on of hands.” Why is patience so important before trusting people with leadership? Have you seen what happens without it? (1 Timothy 5:22)
7. Paul tells Timothy to look after his health (5:23). What does it say about God that such a practical remark stands in the middle of instructions for church leaders? (1 Timothy 5:23)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of one older person and one younger person in the church you could treat this week as a “father/mother” or “brother/sister” – with a call, a visit or a meal.
- Find out together whether there is someone in your church or neighbourhood who is “truly alone”, and agree on one concrete step of help.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray for people in the church who are alone, ill or grieving, by name where appropriate. Then pray for the elders and leaders of your church: for wisdom, protection and faithfulness.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (Days 12–14). The chapter is long; don't try to discuss every verse. Questions 1, 2 and 5 carry the main line.
- The rules about younger widows (5:11–15) can sound harsh or strange today. Explain briefly that the “list” was a church office with lifelong support and a vow of service (Day 13), and don't force the group into a single application.
- Group members may hold different convictions about church structures, elders and the roles of women and men. Let the text speak, follow the line of the devotionals, and keep the conversation respectful; don't settle every disagreement tonight.
- Verse 5:23 (wine) may provoke jokes or touch real struggles with alcohol. Keep the focus on Paul's care for Timothy's health, as Day 14 does, and be sensitive to anyone for whom alcohol is painful.
- Question 3 can touch painful family situations (neglect, broken relationships, caring for parents). Allow silence, and offer to talk afterwards.

Related devotionals: Day 12 – Spiritual Family Ties and Caring for Widows (Part 1) · Day 13 – True Widows and Devoted Service (Part 2) · Day 14 – Double Honour and Fair Discipline for Elders

1 Timothy 5:1–25

1 Do not rebuke an older man harshly, but encourage him as you would a father, younger
men as brothers, 2 older women as mothers,
younger women as sisters, in all purity.

3 Honour widows who are truly widows. 4 But if
a widow has children or grandchildren, let
them first learn to show godliness towards
their own household and to repay their parents, for this is pleasing before God. 5 The one
who is truly a widow and left all alone has set
her hope on God and continues in petitions and
prayers night and day. 6 But the one who lives
for pleasure is dead while she lives. 7 Instruct
them in these things too, so that they may be
above reproach. 8 But if anyone does not provide for his own relatives, and especially for
members of his household, he has denied the
faith and is worse than an unbeliever. 9 Let a
widow be put on the list if she is not less than
sixty years old, the wife of one husband, 10 and
well known for good works: if she has brought
up children, if she has shown hospitality, if she
has washed the feet of the saints, if she has
helped the afflicted, if she has devoted herself
to every good work. 11 But refuse younger widows; for when their desires draw them away
from Christ, they want to marry, 12 and so incur
condemnation for having set aside their first
faithfulness. 13 Besides that, they learn to be
idle, going round from house to house; and not
only idle, but also gossips and busybodies, saying what they should not. 14 So I want younger
widows to marry, to have children, to manage
their households, and to give the adversary no
occasion for slander. 15 For some have already
turned aside to follow Satan. 16 If any believing
woman has widows in her family, let her help
them, and let the church not be burdened, so
that it may help those who are truly widows.

17 Let the elders who lead well be considered
worthy of double honour, especially those who
labour in preaching and teaching. 18 For the
Scripture says, "You shall not muzzle an ox
while it is treading out the grain," and, "The
worker deserves his wages." 19 Do not accept an
accusation against an elder except on the evidence of two or three witnesses. 20 Those who
persist in sin, rebuke in the presence of all, so
that the rest may also stand in fear. 21 I solemnly
charge you before God and Christ Jesus and the
chosen angels to keep these rules without prejudice, doing nothing out of favouritism. 22 Do
not be hasty in the laying on of hands, and do
not take part in the sins of others. Keep yourself pure. 23 No longer drink only water, but use
a little wine for the sake of your stomach and
your frequent illnesses. 24 The sins of some people are obvious, going ahead of them to judgement, but the sins of others follow after them.
25 So also good works are obvious, and even
those that are not cannot remain hidden.

SESSION 6 · 1 TIMOTHY 6:1–21

Real Wealth, Real Life

THE BIG IDEA

True gain is godliness with contentment; so flee the love of money, pursue Christlike character, fight the good fight of the faith – and guard the gospel entrusted to you.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & original language
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

TO GET STARTED

If your house were on fire and everyone were safe, what one thing would you go back for – and why?

READ TOGETHER · 1 TIMOTHY 6:1–21

Let one reader take verses 1–10, a second verses 11–16, and a third verses 17–21. Read verses 15–16 together as a group, like a confession of faith.

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

In the last chapter Paul gathers up the letter. He contrasts teachers who see godliness as "a means of gain" with the real gain of contentment, calls Timothy a "man of God" with four commands – flee, pursue, fight, take hold – breaks out into praise of the King of kings, and ends with one urgent plea: guard what has been entrusted to you.

A LOOK AT THE GREEK

- ***autarkeia* – αὐτάρκεια** "contentment": In Stoic philosophy, the pride of needing nothing. Paul fills it with new content: being satisfied with what God gives, because he is enough (6:6–8).
- ***philargyria* – φιλαργυρία** "love of money": Not money itself, but the love of it is "a root of all kinds of evil" (6:10). It quietly draws people away from the faith and leaves them "pierced … with many pains".
- ***parathēkē* – τὴν παραθήκην φύλαξον** "guard what has been entrusted to you": A deposit handed over for safekeeping: the keeper may not change it or keep it for himself, but must protect it and pass it on intact (6:20). That is how Paul sees the gospel.

DISCUSSION

1. Verses 1 and 2 speak to slaves in the Roman world. We live in a different world, but most of us work under someone's authority. What does it look like to work in a way that brings honour, not shame, to "the name of God"? (1 Timothy 6:1–2)
2. Some people think "that godliness is a means of gain". Where do we see this today – and where in ourselves? (1 Timothy 6:5)
3. "But godliness with contentment is great gain." What makes contentment so hard in our culture? What helps you practise it? (1 Timothy 6:6–8)
4. "For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil." How can you recognise when love of money is growing in your own heart? (1 Timothy 6:10)
5. Flee, pursue, fight, take hold (6:11–12). Which of the four commands is most urgent for you at the moment? (1 Timothy 6:11–12)
6. Paul tells the rich not to set their hope on "the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who richly provides us with everything to enjoy". Compared with most of the world, many of us are rich. What would "rich

in good works" look like for us? (1 Timothy 6:17–19)

7. Looking back over the six sessions: what has God shown you through 1 Timothy, and what will you take with you?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Do a simple "contentment check" this week: each evening, write down three things God has given you that day, and one thing you can give away.
- Choose one concrete act of generosity – time, money or hospitality – and do it before the week is over, quietly.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin by reading 6:15–16 aloud together as praise. Then pray for each other to "take hold of the life that is truly life", and thank God for what the group has received through this study of 1 Timothy.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This is the last session. Leave enough time for question 7 and for prayer; you may drop one of the earlier questions to make room.
- Verses 1–2 on slavery need care. Explain briefly, as Day 15 does, the Roman context and Paul's concern for the gospel's reputation, and don't suggest that the Bible endorses slavery; then move to today's workplaces.
- Money is a personal topic. Avoid comparing incomes, and don't put anyone on the spot; let people share what they are comfortable with.
- Point out the contrast between the false teachers' "gain" (6:5) and true "gain" (6:6) – the group often discovers it themselves if you ask what word appears twice.
- Consider ending with a short celebration or meal together. If your group wants to continue, the letter of 2 Timothy is a natural next step.

Related devotionals: Day 15 – Contentment versus the Trap of the Love of Money · Day 16 – Flee, Pursue, Fight – and Guard What Has Been Entrusted

1 Timothy 6:1–21

[1] Let all who are under the yoke as slaves regard
their own masters as worthy of all honour, so
that the name of God and the teaching may not
be blasphemed. [2] Those who have believing
masters must not look down on them because
they are brothers; rather, they must serve them
all the better, because those who benefit from
their good service are believers and beloved.
Teach and urge these things.

[3] If anyone teaches a different doctrine and does
not agree with the sound words of our Lord
Jesus Christ and with the teaching that accords
with godliness, [4] he is puffed up and under-
stands nothing. He has an unhealthy craving
for controversies and quarrels about words,
which produce envy, strife, slander, evil suspi-
cions, [5] and constant friction among people
who are corrupted in mind and deprived of the
truth, who think that godliness is a means of
gain. [6] But godliness with contentment is great
gain. [7] For we brought nothing into the world,
and we cannot take anything out of it. [8] But if
we have food and clothing, with these we will
be content. [9] But those who want to be rich fall
into temptation, into a trap, and into many
senseless and harmful desires that plunge peo-
ple into ruin and destruction. [10] For the love of
money is a root of all kinds of evil. Some, by
craving it, have wandered away from the faith
and pierced themselves with many pains.

[11] But you, man of God, flee from these things.
Pursue righteousness, godliness, faith, love, en-
durance, gentleness. [12] Fight the good fight of
the faith. Take hold of the eternal life to which
you were called and about which you made the
good confession in the presence of many wit-
nesses. [13] I charge you before God, who gives life
to all things, and before Christ Jesus, who in
his testimony before Pontius Pilate made the
good confession, [14] to keep the commandment
spotless and above reproach until the appear-
ing of our Lord Jesus Christ,

[15] which he will display at the proper time –
he who is the blessed and only Sovereign,
the King of kings and Lord of lords,
[16] who alone has immortality,
who dwells in unapproachable light,
whom no one has ever seen or can see.
To him be honour and eternal dominion.
Amen.

[17] As for the rich in this present age, instruct
them not to be arrogant, nor to set their hope
on the uncertainty of riches, but on God, who
richly provides us with everything to enjoy.
[18] They are to do good, to be rich in good works,
to be generous and ready to share, [19] so storing
up for themselves a good foundation for the fu-
ture, so that they may take hold of the life that
is truly life.

[20] O Timothy, guard what has been entrusted to
you. Turn away from irreverent, empty chatter
and the contradictions of what is falsely called
knowledge, [21] which some have professed and
so have swerved from the faith. Grace be with
you all.